

CONTROLLING OFFICER'S REPLY**HHB198****(Question Serial No. 0217)**Head: (37) Department of HealthSubhead (No. & title): (-) Not SpecifiedProgramme: (2) Disease PreventionControlling Officer: Director of Health (Dr. Ronald LAM)Director of Bureau: Secretary for HealthQuestion:

Regarding the promotion and implementation of the Elderly Health Care Voucher Scheme (EHVS), please inform this Committee of:

1. the detailed breakdown of the total expenditure on the EHVS over the past 3 years, as well as the estimated expenditure of the scheme for 2025-26;
2. the number of voucher claim transactions, the amount claimed and the average, median as well as the maximum and minimum amount claimed per transaction in the past 3 years, broken down by type of service;
3. the number of healthcare service providers enrolled under the EHVS and the participation rate of each healthcare service provider in the scheme, broken down by type of service;
4. the respective number of complaints against the abuse of vouchers received and investigations conducted by the Department of Health, and prosecutions as a result (by type of healthcare service provider); as well as the respective number of cases with investigation completed, found to be substantiated, and related to fraud or improper voucher claims, and the number of service providers and voucher recipients disqualified from the EHVS for breaching the scheme rules in the past 3 years; and
5. the number of service providers who withdrew from the EHVS over the past 3 years, broken down by type of service.

Asked by: Hon CHAN Hoi-yan (LegCo internal reference no.: 8)

Reply:

1.

The table below shows the actual/estimated expenditure on the Elderly Health Care Voucher Scheme (EHVS) from the financial year 2022-23 to 2024-25:

Year	Actual/Estimated Expenditure on the EHVS (\$ billion)
2022-23	2.79 (Actual)
2023-24	3.33 (Actual)
2024-25	3.45 (Revised Estimate)

The estimated expenditure for 2025-26 for the EHVS is \$4.15 billion.

2.

The tables below show the number of voucher claim transactions, the amount of vouchers claimed and the average, median, maximum and minimum amounts per claim transaction under the EHVS (including the Elderly Health Care Voucher Greater Bay Area Pilot Scheme) by types of healthcare service provider/medical institution in the Greater Bay Area (GBA) enrolled in the EHVS in the past 3 years:

Number of Voucher Claim Transactions

	2022	2023 ^{Note 1}	2024
Healthcare service providers in Hong Kong			
Medical Practitioners	1 954 032	2 325 617	2 444 952
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	1 647 630	1 965 635	2 160 315
Dentists	288 532	331 342	331 567
Occupational Therapists	4 177	4 232	3 003
Physiotherapists	37 603	45 673	43 341
Medical Laboratory Technologists	14 593	15 441	14 503
Radiographers	20 761	22 659	23 285
Nurses	9 376	11 196	10 800
Chiropractors	8 841	10 331	8 724
Optometrists	161 156	230 239	175 563
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	-	784	1 636
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	-	2	-
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	-	609	1 356
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	-	5	7
Sub-total (Hong Kong):	4 146 701	4 963 765	5 219 052
Medical institutions in the GBA:	32 356	38 462	77 918
Total:	4 179 057	5 002 227	5 296 970

Amount of Vouchers Claimed (in HK\$'000)

	2022	2023 ^{Note 1}	2024
Healthcare service providers in Hong Kong			
Medical Practitioners	1,059,052	1,270,495	1,363,308
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	854,324	1,140,988	1,227,911
Dentists	343,327	413,222	402,347
Occupational Therapists	4,518	4,455	3,404
Physiotherapists	17,743	22,726	23,083
Medical Laboratory Technologists	13,393	14,712	13,353
Radiographers	24,635	29,503	34,556
Nurses	9,878	11,168	10,427
Chiropractors	5,080	5,955	5,467
Optometrists	233,912	352,743	255,505
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	-	2,693	5,040
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	-	4	-

Dietitians ^{Note 2}	-	829	1,110
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	-	5	7
Sub-total (Hong Kong):	2,565,862	3,269,498	3,345,518
Medical institutions in the GBA:	10,949	11,883	39,339
Total:	2,576,811	3,281,381	3,384,857

Average Amount of Vouchers per Claim Transaction (HK\$)

	2022	2023 ^{Note 1}	2024
Healthcare service providers in Hong Kong			
Medical Practitioners	542	546	558
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	519	580	568
Dentists	1,190	1,247	1,213
Occupational Therapists	1,082	1,053	1,134
Physiotherapists	472	498	533
Medical Laboratory Technologists	918	953	921
Radiographers	1,187	1,302	1,484
Nurses	1,054	997	965
Chiropractors	575	576	627
Optometrists	1,451	1,532	1,455
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	N/A	3,435	3,081
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	N/A	2,000	N/A
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	N/A	1,361	819
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	N/A	1,000	1,000
Medical institutions in the GBA ^{Note 3}	338	309	505

Median Amount of Vouchers per Claim Transaction (HK\$)

	2022	2023 ^{Note 1}	2024
Healthcare service providers in Hong Kong			
Medical Practitioners	380	400	410
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	310	320	324
Dentists	800	835	800
Occupational Therapists	350	300	300
Physiotherapists	330	320	350
Medical Laboratory Technologists	680	720	700
Radiographers	720	800	900
Nurses	525	500	490
Chiropractors	560	560	600
Optometrists	1,700	1,880	1,748
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	N/A	2,121	1,905
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	N/A	1,800	N/A
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	N/A	1,105	310
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	N/A	1,200	1,000

Medical institutions in the GBA Note 3	123	114	186
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Range of Maximum and Minimum Voucher Amounts per Claim Transaction (HK\$)

	Range of Maximum Voucher Amounts per Claim Transaction (HK\$) ^{Note 4}		
	2022	2023 ^{Note 1}	2024
Healthcare service providers in Hong Kong			
Medical Practitioners	7,751 – 8,000	>8,000	>8,000
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	7,751 – 8,000	>8,000	>8,000
Dentists	7,751 – 8,000	>8,000	>8,000
Occupational Therapists	7,501 – 7,750	7,751 – 8,000	7,751 – 8,000
Physiotherapists	7,751 – 8,000	>8,000	>8,000
Medical Laboratory Technologists	7,751 – 8,000	7,751 – 8,000	7,751 – 8,000
Radiographers	7,751 – 8,000	>8,000	>8,000
Nurses	7,751 – 8,000	>8,000	>8,000
Chiropractors	6,501 – 6,750	6,001 – 6,250	7,751 – 8,000
Optometrists	1,751 – 2,000	1,751 – 2,000	1,751 – 2,000
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	N/A	>8,000	>8,000
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	N/A	1,751 – 2,000	N/A
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	N/A	7,751 – 8,000	4,751 – 5,000
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	N/A	1,251 – 1,500	1,751 – 2,000
Medical institutions in the GBA Note 3	7,751 – 8,000	7,251 – 7,500	>8,000

	Range of Minimum Voucher Amounts per Claim Transaction (HK\$)		
	2022	2023 ^{Note 1}	2024
Healthcare service providers in Hong Kong			
Medical Practitioners	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Dentists	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Occupational Therapists	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Physiotherapists	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Medical Laboratory Technologists	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Radiographers	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Nurses	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Chiropractors	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Optometrists	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	N/A	1 – 250	1 – 250
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	N/A	1,751 – 2,000	N/A
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	N/A	1 – 250	1 – 250
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	N/A	501 – 750	1 – 250

Medical institutions in the GBA	1 - 250	1 - 250	1 - 250
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Note 1: Starting from 28 July 2023, the EHVS allows shared use of vouchers between 2 eligible elderly persons in spousal relationship upon their mutual consent and completion of procedures to pair up their voucher accounts. Furthermore, a three-year Elderly Health Care Voucher Pilot Reward Scheme (Pilot Reward Scheme) was launched under the EHVS on 13 November 2023.

Note 2: Since 28 April 2023, the coverage of the EHVS has been extended to include primary healthcare services provided by 4 categories of healthcare professions under the Accredited Registers Scheme for Healthcare Professions (AR Scheme) (namely audiologists, clinical psychologists, dietitians and speech therapists).

Note 3: Under the existing EHVS, private healthcare professionals in Hong Kong may enrol in the scheme as healthcare service providers on an individual basis, while medical institutions in the GBA participate in the scheme on a hospital/medical institution basis. Eligible elderly persons may use Elderly Health Care Vouchers to pay for the fee of outpatient healthcare services, such as physical examination, continuous preventive healthcare and chronic disease management, etc., provided by the designated departments at medical institutions in the GBA, and the statistics on the related healthcare services are compiled on the basis of services as provided by the respective designated departments, rather than individual healthcare professions. As such, any direct comparison between the average amount of vouchers per claim transaction for healthcare service providers in Hong Kong and that of medical institutions in the GBA is not appropriate. Nor do the figures reflect the levels of primary healthcare service charges of either region.

Note 4: Due to the shared use of vouchers between spouses under the EHVS starting from 28 July 2023 and the \$500 reward under the Pilot Reward Scheme launched on 13 November in the same year (see Note 1 above) is not subject to the accumulation limit, the maximum voucher amount per claim transaction may exceed \$8,000.

3.

The table below shows the number and participation rate of healthcare service providers in Hong Kong enrolled in the EHVS as at the end of 2024, by types of profession:

	Number of Healthcare Service Providers (Participation Rate ^{Note 1})
Medical Practitioners	3 451 (55%)
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	4 551 (60%)
Dentists	1 569 (73%)
Occupational Therapists	191 (11%)
Physiotherapists	880 (33%)
Medical Laboratory Technologists	54 (4%)
Radiographers	67 (5%)
Nurses	298 (1%)
Chiropractors	171 (59%)
Optometrists	912 (85%)
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	40 (57%)
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	15 (3%)
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	46 (34%)
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	42 (13%)
Total:	12 287

Note 1: In calculating the EHVS participation rate of the first 10 types of healthcare service providers (i.e. medical practitioners, Chinese medicine practitioners, dentists, occupational therapists,

physiotherapists, medical laboratory technologists, radiographers, nurses, chiropractors and optometrists), those healthcare professionals practising in the public sector or are economically inactive (e.g. not practising in Hong Kong) have been excluded.

Note 2: Since 28 April 2023, the coverage of the EHVS has been extended to include primary healthcare services provided by 4 categories of healthcare professions under the AR Scheme (namely audiologists, clinical psychologists, dietitians and speech therapists). In calculating the percentage of participating healthcare service providers of these 4 professions under the EHVS, the numbers of registrants on the registers of the relevant healthcare professional bodies accredited under the AR Scheme of the Government have been used.

4.

The table below shows the number of complaints (including media reports and relevant intelligence) against healthcare service providers enrolled in the EHVS received by the Department of Health (DH) from 2022 to 2024:

	2022	2023	2024	Total
Number of complaints against healthcare service providers enrolled in the EHVS received by the DH	45	54	88	187

These complaint cases, involving operational procedures, suspected fraud, improper voucher claims and issues related to service charges, were mainly against Chinese medicine practitioners, medical practitioners, optometrists and dentists. The DH would conduct investigation into every complaint received and take appropriate actions/measures when violation of the terms and conditions of the EHVS Agreement was found, including issuing advisory/warning letters to the relevant healthcare service providers, withholding reimbursements or recovering paid reimbursements, disqualifying healthcare service providers from participating in the EHVS, and referring cases to the Police and the relevant professional regulatory boards/councils for follow-up as appropriate.

Among the complaint cases against healthcare service providers enrolled under the EHVS received by the DH in the past 3 years, as at end-December 2024, investigation of 29 cases was completed, of which 11 were found to be substantiated or partially substantiated. The DH has disqualified 3 healthcare service providers from participating in the EHVS and has referred 6 cases to the Police for follow-up (of which the investigation of 2 cases was completed with no prosecutions made and 4 cases are still under investigation).

5.

The table below shows the number of healthcare service providers in Hong Kong enrolling in and withdrawing from the EHVS in the past 3 years, by types of profession:

Service Provider Category	2022 Note 1			2023			2024 Note 1		
	Enrolments	Withdrawals	Net Enrolments	Enrolments	Withdrawals	Net Enrolments	Enrolments	Withdrawals	Net Enrolments
Medical Practitioners	365	163	202	226	51	175	218	470	(252)
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	362	169	193	316	30	286	332	147	185
Dentists	77	42	35	154	8	146	120	28	92

Service Provider Category	2022 Note 1			2023			2024 Note 1		
	Enrolments	Withdrawals	Net Enrolments	Enrolments	Withdrawals	Net Enrolments	Enrolments	Withdrawals	Net Enrolments
Occupational Therapists	18	12	6	35	4	31	24	20	4
Physiotherapists	108	31	77	111	13	98	138	84	54
Medical Laboratory Technologists	2	7	(5)	2	3	(1)	4	7	(3)
Radiographers	7	8	(1)	11	1	10	10	6	4
Nurses	45	59	(14)	36	6	30	44	36	8
Chiropractors	9	6	3	31	3	28	13	6	7
Optometrists	23	23	0	56	6	50	52	28	24
Audiologists Note 2	N/A	N/A	N/A	34	1	33	10	3	7
Clinical Psychologists Note 2	N/A	N/A	N/A	13	-	13	2	-	2
Dietitians Note 2	N/A	N/A	N/A	36	-	36	10	-	10
Speech Therapists Note 2	N/A	N/A	N/A	39	-	39	7	4	3
Total:	1 016	520	496	1 100	126	974	984	839	145

Note 1: The number of healthcare service providers withdrawing from the EHVS in 2022 and 2024 is relatively higher as the Health Care Voucher Division of the DH updates the database of healthcare service providers every 2 years.

Note 2: Since 28 April 2023, the coverage of the EHVS has been extended to include primary healthcare services provided by 4 categories of healthcare professions under the AR Scheme (namely audiologists, clinical psychologists, dietitians and speech therapists).

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